THREAT INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING

Classified: Lazarus Group Campaign — Operation GhostPay

Date: October 08, 2026 | Classification: RESTRICTED | Source: Joint Threat Analysis Unit (JTAU)

Reference ID: JTAU-2026-LZG-0084

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1. BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT (BLUF)

Threat Actor: Lazarus Group (DPRK-linked APT38 subgroup) has launched a multi-stage cyber intrusion campaign targeting the Financial Core Payment Gateway infrastructure across Southeast Asian financial institutions. The campaign, codenamed Operation GhostPay, combines spear-phishing delivery, credential theft, and ransomware payload deployment. Intelligence from SIEM, cyber sensors, and OSINT confirms active Command and Control (C2) communication from malicious IP 203.0.113.199 and domain evil-command-node.xyz. Also it is Severity-CRITICAL. Immediate defensive action and threat cluster escalation is recommended.

2. THREAT ACTOR PROFILE

Field	Details
Name	Lazarus Group / APT38
Attribution	Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK)
Motivation	Financial gain, espionage, disruption of Western banking systems
TTP Framework	MITRE ATT&CK: T1566 (Phishing), T1055 (Process Injection), T1486 (Data Encrypted for Impact)
Known Campaigns	Operation AppleJeus (2018), WannaCry (2017), SWIFT banking heist (2016)
Current Campaign	Operation GhostPay — targeting financial payment gateways (Oct 2026)

3. INDICATORS OF COMPROMISE (IOCs)

The following indicators have been confirmed across SIEM logs, network sensor telemetry, and third-party threat intelligence feeds:

IOC Type	Value	Confidence
IP	203.0.113.199	98%

Address		
IP Address	198.51.100.45	91%
Domain	evil-command-node.xyz	96%
Domain	ghostpay-loader.net	88%
File Hash (MD5)	e99a18c428cb38d5f260853678922e03	99%
File Hash (SHA256)	3f5a2c7b8e1d4f09ac6b2e8f5c0d3a17b2e9f6c4d8a1e3b7f0c5a9d2e8b4f1a3	99%
File Name	payment_gateway_update.exe	85%
Threat Actor	Lazarus Group	95%
Target System	Financial Core Payment Gateway Server	100%
Severity	CRITICAL	

4. ATTACK TIMELINE

- **Day 1 - 00:00:** Spear-phishing email with malicious attachment sent to 3 financial institution employees
- **Day 1 - 08:30:** Victim opens attachment; Cobalt Strike stager executes in memory
- **Day 1 - 09:00:** C2 beacon established to 203.0.113.199 over HTTPS port 443
- **Day 2 - 14:00:** Lateral movement initiated; credential harvesting via Mimikatz
- **Day 3 - 02:15:** Ransomware payload (payment_gateway_update.exe) deployed on PAY-GW-01
- **Day 3 - 02:20:** Mass file encryption initiated on Financial Core Payment Gateway Server
- **Day 3 - 02:25:** Data exfiltration detected to ghostpay-loader.net (198.51.100.45)
- **Day 3 - 03:00:** SIEM alert triggered; automated correlation engine activates
- **Day 3 - 03:05:** Threat cluster CRITICAL escalation; BLUF report auto-generated

5. AFFECTED TARGETS

Primary Target: Financial Core Payment Gateway Server (Host: PAY-GW-01)
Secondary Target: Internal AD Domain Controller (Host: DC-CORP-01)
Tertiary Target: Customer Database Server (Host: DB-CUST-02)
Sector: Banking and Financial Services
Geographic Region: Southeast Asia — Singapore, Indonesia, Vietnam

6. RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- Immediately block IP 203.0.113.199 and 198.51.100.45 on all edge firewalls and perimeter WAFs.

- Sinkhole DNS for domains: evil-command-node.xyz and ghostpay-loader.net.
- Scan all systems for file hash e99a18c428cb38d5f260853678922e03 (MD5) and isolate affected hosts.
- Reset all privileged account credentials and enable hardware MFA enforcement.
- Deploy EDR signatures for Cobalt Strike Beacon process injection patterns (T1055).
- Enable enhanced SIEM alerting for SWIFT transaction anomalies and abnormal fund transfers.
- Notify relevant national CERT and Financial Intelligence Units within 24 hours.
- Human analyst review of auto-generated BLUF report is MANDATORY before cluster escalation closure.

7. ANALYST NOTES

This briefing was machine-generated by the Sarvatobhadra Threat Intelligence Correlation Platform using multi-source evidence correlation (SIEM: 4 alerts, Cyber Sensor: 2 events, OSINT: 3 feeds, Intel Report: 1 document). HUMAN-IN-THE-LOOP REVIEW IS REQUIRED before operational response escalation. The correlation engine assigned a Threat Score of 94/100 (CRITICAL priority) based on multi-source evidence and Lazarus Group TTPs historical pattern matching.
